

SETTING AND MAINTAINING BOUNDARIES # 64

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Learn how childhood trauma resulted in interpersonal problems and addiction.
2. Resolve past childhood/family issues, leading to less fear, anger, and depression, and greater self-esteem and confidence.
3. Gain an understanding of personal power to set boundaries for oneself, and the right to protect oneself emotionally and physically.
4. Learn to find balance and flexibility regarding roles or boundaries in relationships.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO HAVE EXPERIENCED CHILDHOOD TRAUMA

- Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?
- Am I Teaching My Children Addictive Patterns?
- Corresponding with My Childhood Self
- Moving On with My Life
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Understanding Family History
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- Working through Shame

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Setting and Maintaining Boundaries” activity should be preceded by discussion, to ensure that the client understands the concept of boundaries in relationships, and some probing of what he/she considers healthy (it is important to keep cultural considerations in mind when examining norms and mores with the client). When a client has a clear and functional goal, this exercise is useful in conducting a relationship inventory and identifying areas for growth. Follow-up might include planning specific strategies for difficult situations described in the client’s work on this activity, and sharing those plans with the counselor, treatment group, and program sponsor.

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When we have healthy boundaries in our relationships, we accept people and actions that are positive and helpful, but protect ourselves from people and actions that are harmful to us. In trying to protect ourselves, we may have learned to keep very rigid boundaries, trusting no one and allowing no one to get close to us emotionally. On the other hand, in our search for love and acceptance we may leave ourselves too vulnerable, letting people hurt us too easily. Healthy boundaries let us choose whom to trust, how much to trust them, and what actions to accept from them, letting us have positive relationships while protecting us from abuse. We also learn to set boundaries on what we do and say to others, respecting their rights as well as our own.

1. List some people with whom you have difficulty setting or maintaining healthy boundaries, along with situations where you have trouble with them, and what the results have been.

Person	Situation	What Happens	How You Are Affected
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

2. Are there people, situations, or actions about which you are able to set and maintain healthy boundaries? _____ If so, please list them here:

Person	Situation	Action or Behavior
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

3. Why do you think you are able to set and maintain boundaries with the people, situations, or actions on the second list, but not with those on the first list?

4. How can you use the same methods that work with the second list for the people, situations, or actions on the first list, or use other methods to get the same healthy results?

5. What changes would you like to make in your boundaries to help you live a healthy life?

6. What do you need to do to make these changes?

7. What will you do if others are resistant to accepting your boundaries?
